economic, communal, international and on refugees?'[49] This was when Nehru decided to take the bull by the horns.

In a sudden 'bombshell' move, the prime minister formally resigned from the Congress Working Committee and the party's Central Election Board. This was the first time he had ever done so. It was also the last. He was throwing down the gauntlet. A full year of 'controversy between him and the Congress President' led to this ultimatum on 7 August 1951.[50] The prime minister had spent a year in bruising battles with the Hindu traditionalists, but he was now in a stronger position within his party. Patel's death in December 1950 had also deprived the Hindu traditionalists of a powerful supporter.

By resigning, Nehru had forced the party's hand. He first won a vote of confidence in the Congress Parliamentary Party on 21 August. By 8 September, he was also elected Congress president, forcing Tandon to resign from the position. Independent India's first election was just a month away. With this victory within his own party, Nehru was now 'monarch of all that he surveys in this country', as summed up by a newspaper report.[51] It had been nothing short of a battle for the control of the party machinery. The Congress's Hindu traditionalists agreed with Mookerjee's critique of Nehru's Pakistan policy but when push came to shove, they chose not to split the party and failed to oust Nehru. As prime minister, Nehru had largely 'kept away' from organisational matters until his decisions were publicly challenged. It was Patel who had largely managed the party machine until his death. Now, Nehru wrested control.

The bitter war 'between two forces within Congress—the secular nationalists and the Hindu traditionalists' was closely watched by both the RSS and the Hindu Mahasabha. 'Nehru's victory was by no means certain even as late as August 1951, and until the outcome of the struggle was clear, the Hindu traditionalists hesitated to form a strong party to challenge the party,' Graham observed.[52] If Nehru had lost the leadership, it is not inconceivable that both Mookerjee and the RSS would have been comfortable with a Congress that could have turned Hindu nationalist. Nehru's triumph meant that such an option was out of reach. The Jan Sangh had become inevitable: it was launched nationally the very next month.